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Faculty of Regional Development and International Studies



Personal Experiences of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe

Master's Thesis

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Contents

STATUTORY DECLARATION	1
ACKNOWLEDGEMENT	5
DEDICATION.....	6
ABSTRACT	7
ABSTRAKT	8
INTRODUCTION	9
1.1 Background of the study	9
1.2 Importance of studying personal experiences of LGBTQ individuals.....	11
1.3 Legal status of LGBTQ rights in Africa.....	12
1.3.1. Predominance of Criminalization.	12
1.3.2 Constitutional Ambiguity and Progressive Exceptions.	12
1.3.3 Legislative Backlash and "Anti-Homosexuality" Laws	13
1.3.4 Regional Human Rights Mechanisms	13
1.3.5 Emerging Trends and Activism	13
1.4 Statement of the problem	14
1.4.1 Invisibility of Contemporary Realities.	15
1.4.2 Epistemic Erasure of Resilience.	15
1.4.3 Intersectional Data Deficits.	15
1.5 Study Objectives.....	15
1.7 Research Questions.....	16
1.8 Scope of the study.....	16
2. Literature Review	17
2.1 Definition of LGBTQ+.....	17
2.2 Theoretical Framework: Minority Stress Theory	18
2.3 Zimbabwe LGBTQ Laws.....	19
2.3.1 Political Weaponization of Homophobia.	21
2.3.2 Sociocultural and Religious Dimensions.....	22

2.3.3 Lived Realities: Stigma and Resistance	22
2.4 Plight of LGBTQ Persons in Africa	22
2.4.1 The Complex Landscape of LGBTQ+ Rights and Realities in Southern Africa.	23
2.4.2 The Repressive Landscape of LGBTQ+ Rights in East Africa: Persecution, Politics, and Resilience.....	25
2.4.3 The Complex Terrain of LGBTQ+ Rights in West Africa: Criminalization, Social Hostility, and Fragile Resistance.....	26
3 Methodology	29
3.1 Research Philosophy	29
3.3 Sampling	30
3.5 Data Collection Instruments	31
3.5.1 In-depth Interviews.....	31
3.5.2 Data Collection Procedure	32
3.6 Ethical Considerations.....	32
3.6.1 Informed Consent:	33
3.6.2 Confidentiality and Anonymization:.....	33
3.6.3 Data Storage and Access Control:.....	33
3.7 Data Analysis Framework for research on LGBT Experiences in Zimbabwe.	33
4 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION: PERSONAL EXPERIENCES OF LGBTQ COMMUNITY MEMBERS IN ZIMBABWE.....	35
4.1 RESEARCH SAMPLE CHARACTERISTICS	35
4.2 COMMUNITY UNDERSTANDING AND AWARENESS OF LGBTQ+ IDENTITIES	36
4.3 DISCRIMINATION IN THE WORKPLACE	38
4.4 RELIGIOUS AND CULTURAL INFLUENCES	41
4.4.1 Religious Institutions and the Limits for Safe Spaces for LGBTQ+ persons.....	41
4.4.2 The Church as a Potential Safe Space for LGBTQ+	43
4.4.3 Anti LGBTQ+ Chants by Politicians	44
4.5 Criminalization- Fear of Legal Repercussion	44
4.6 Consequences of Disclosure and Involuntary Outing Among LGBTQ+ Individuals in Zimbabwe .	45
4.6.1 Family Disownment and Social Exclusion	45

4.6.2 Blackmail and Extortion	47
4.6.3 Violence and Abuse.....	49
4.7 Transgender Visibility.....	50
4.8 COPING MECHANISMS.....	52
4.8.1 Concealing Sexuality	52
4.8.2 Selective Disclosure.....	52
4.8.3 Utilization of Safe Spaces.....	53
4.8.4 Establishing Safe Spaces and Substance Dependency	54
5 CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS	55
5.1 CONCLUSION	55
5.2 RECOMMENDATIONS.....	56
REFERENCES.....	58
List of Abbreviations	62
Appendix 1: Informed Consent Guide	63
Overview of the Study:	63
Purpose of the Study.....	63
Appendix 2: Semi-Structured Interview Guide	65

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THE MARATHON CONTINUES...

DEDICATION

Dedicated to my parents, Fungai and Agnes for their unconditional love and endless support. I am so grateful for all the sacrifices you made to give me a better life.

ABSTRACT

This thesis aims to explore the lived experiences of LGBTQ community members in a country where same-sex relationships are prohibited. This is exacerbated by the Constitution of Zimbabwe Section 78, which defines marriage as exclusively between a man and a woman. The aim of this research is to find out how the LGBTQ community navigates their daily life and how this has impacted them and to understand how they have been resilient. Discrimination and social stigma continue to shape everyday life, and this is further necessitated by religious and cultural norms. This is shown by the fact that 32 out of 54 African countries criminalize same-sex marriages. The study employed qualitative research design and snowball sampling was used to recruit participants after GALZ provided the first participants who then later started referring to other participants. The researcher conducted 18 telephonic interviews as well as a few on Microsoft teams. The data gathered was analyzed using thematic analysis from recurring issues mentioned by the study participants. The research sought to explore the personal experiences of LGBTQ persons. This was done by asking them a set of questions in which the researcher was able to probe for more answers by asking follow-up questions. The study determined that religious and cultural norms are the drivers and major perpetrators of discrimination and stigma of the LGBTQ community in Zimbabwe. The LGBTQ community still suffer from persecution as they are always being told that homosexuality is a western norm and it is un-African hence cannot be accepted. The findings of the research showed that LGBTQ community suffers rejection from family, and the society at large hence they conceal their sexuality which is a survival mechanism. Some of them come out of the closet but they face family rejection and this creates stress leading to depression. Most of the LGBTQ members have resorted to use of drugs and alcohol so that they can cope and not stress as much.

Keywords: LGBTQ, homosexuality, sexual orientation, personal experiences, human rights, discrimination

ABSTRAKT

Tato práce si klade za cíl prozkoumat životní zkušenosti členů LGBTQ komunity v zemi, kde jsou vztahy osob stejného pohlaví zakázány. Tuto situaci ještě zhoršuje § 78 Ústavy Zimbabwe, který definuje manželství výhradně mezi mužem a ženou. Cílem tohoto výzkumu je zjistit, jak se LGBTQ komunita orientuje ve svém každodenním životě a jaký to mělo na ni dopad, a pochopit, jak je vůči tomu odolná. Diskriminace a sociální stigma nadále formují každodenní život a to je dále umocněno náboženskými a kulturními normami. To dokazuje skutečnost, že 32 z 54 afrických zemí kriminalizuje manželství osob stejného pohlaví. Studie použila kvalitativní výzkumný design a k náboru účastníků byl použit metodu sněhové koule poté, co GALZ poskytla první účastníky, kteří později začali odkazovat na další účastníky. Výzkumník provedl 18 telefonických rozhovorů a rozhovorů na platformě Microsoft Teams. Shromážděná data byla analyzována pomocí tematické analýzy na základě opakujících se problémů zmiňovaných účastníky studie. Výzkum se snažil prozkoumat osobní zkušenosti LGBTQ osob. Toho bylo dosaženo položením sady otázek, na které výzkumník mohl získat další odpovědi kladením doplňujících otázek. Studie zjistila, že náboženské a kulturní normy jsou hnací silou a hlavními příčinami diskriminace a stigmatizace LGBTQ komunity v Zimbabwe. LGBTQ komunita stále trpí pronásledováním, protože je jí neustále říkano, že homosexualita je západní norma a že je neafrická, a proto ji nelze akceptovat. Výsledky výzkumu ukázaly, že LGBTQ komunita trpí odmítáním ze strany rodiny i společnosti jako celku, a proto skrývají svou sexualitu, aby mohli žít život bez diskriminace. Někteří z nich se s tím svěřují, ale čelí odmítnutí ze strany rodiny, což vytváří stres vedoucí k depresi. Většina členů LGBTQ se uchyluje k užívání drog a alkoholu, aby se s tím vyrovnali a nestresovali se tolik.

Klíčová slova: LGBTQ, homosexualita, sexuální orientace, osobní zkušenosti, lidská práva, diskriminace

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the study

The personal experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe are shaped by a complex interplay of legal repression, societal stigma, and cultural norms, which collectively marginalize and endanger LGBTQ communities. Zimbabwe's legal framework, particularly Sections 73 and 78 of the Criminal Law Code, criminalizes same-sex relations, framing them as "unnatural acts" punishable by imprisonment (Epprecht, 2013). While enforcement of these laws is inconsistent, their existence legitimizes societal discrimination, fostering an environment where violence, harassment, and exclusion are normalized. Former President Robert Mugabe's public vilification of LGBTQ individuals as *"worse than dogs and pigs"* further entrenched institutionalized homophobia, aligning state rhetoric with conservative religious and cultural ideologies (Muparamoto, 2021).

Zimbabwe's history of criminalizing same-sex relations was further agitated under leaders like Mugabe (1987-2017) and Mnangagwa (2018-present) whose hostile public statements against LGBTQ rights contributed to the stigma. The personal experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe reflect a complex interplay of systemic discrimination deeply entrenched in cultural and religious homophobia, which creates a hostile environment for LGBTQ individuals, even as grassroots organizations advocate for change. Zimbabwe's legal system explicitly criminalizes same-sex relations, with penalties of up to one year in prison for "consensual sodomy" (Human Rights Watch, 2022). While prosecutions are rare, the law legitimizes societal discrimination, emboldening harassment and violence. A 2022 report by GALZ (Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe) documented cases of police brutality, including arbitrary arrests of LGBTQ individuals under vague charges like *"disorderly conduct"* for example, transgender women being targeted for "cross-dressing" under archaic municipal bylaws. These legal threats force many to live in secrecy, exacerbating mental health struggles (Muparamoto & Chireshe, 2022).

Socially, LGBTQ+ Zimbabweans face pervasive discrimination in employment, healthcare, and housing. Many conceal their identities to avoid ostracization or violence, a survival strategy termed "strategic invisibility" (Chabata & Dorras, 2022). For example, queer individuals often avoid healthcare services due to fears of mistreatment, exacerbating vulnerabilities like HIV/AIDS, a critical issue in a country with a 12.9% adult prevalence rate (UNAIDS, 2022). Stigma also isolates

LGBTQ youth, who report high rates of familial rejection and homelessness, compounding mental health crises such as depression and suicidality (Human Rights Watch, 2023).

Familial rejection remains a critical issue. A qualitative study by Mhiripiri & Mutsvairo (2022) highlighted narratives of LGBTQ youth expelled from their homes after disclosing their identities. In Harare's impoverished townships, homeless LGBTQ individuals face exploitation, with some coerced into survival sex work. A famous Zimbabwean transgender woman named Tatelicious during her discovery evolved into sex work; she narrated her ordeal on her Facebook page GALZ's 2022 survey notes that 40% of respondents experienced familial violence, often justified by religious or cultural beliefs. One interviewee recounted, *"My father said I was possessed by demons... I had to flee to a safehouse run by activists."* Cultural and religious conservatism remains a significant barrier. Zimbabwean society often conflates queerness with *"Western decadence,"* a rhetoric weaponized by politicians to deflect criticism of governance failures (Epprecht, 2013). However, ethnographic work reveals that pre-colonial Zimbabwe hosted fluid gender and sexual identities, complicating claims of LGBTQ+ identities as "un-African" (Tamale, 2020). This historical erasure underscores the politicization of sexuality in post-colonial nation-building.

Despite Zimbabwe's progress in HIV/AIDS management, LGBTQ+ individuals face barriers due to stigma. Same-sex relationships are excluded from national HIV prevention programs, and healthcare providers often refuse services. A 2022 study in Culture, Health & Sexuality found that gay men and transgender women avoided clinics for fear of exposure, leading to untreated HIV and STIs. Activists reported that even NGO-led initiatives face resistance; for instance, PrEP (pre-exposure prophylaxis) campaigns are criticized as "promoting homosexuality" (Chikwiri & Gukurume, 2022). Social media has become a double-edged sword, whilst platforms like WhatsApp and Facebook provide clandestine support networks, LGBTQ+ individuals face blackmail and discrimination. A 2022 report by Digital Society of Zimbabwe (2018) documented cases where private messages were leaked to families or employers, leading to job loss or ostracization. Activists also noted increased state surveillance of online LGBTQ advocacy, with threats of prosecution under cyber-crime laws.

Despite these challenges, grassroots organizations like GALZ and Trans Smart Trust have amplified visibility. Safe spaces, such as clandestine support groups and art therapy workshops, legal aid, and health resources, while digital platforms enable safer solidarity-building

(Muparamoto, 2021). Queer activists navigate risks by framing their advocacy within human rights frameworks, leveraging international alliances to pressure the state (Currier & Cruz, 2020). In 2022, GALZ launched a campaign using anonymized video testimonials to humanize LGBTQ struggles, strategically avoiding state censorship. Additionally, transnational alliances, such as partnerships with South African LGBTQ groups, provide resources for asylum seekers and advocacy training (Macharia, 2022).

Overall, the experiences of LGBTQ+ Zimbabweans underscore the intersection of legal violence, cultural stigma, and socioeconomic precarity. While systemic oppression persists, community-led initiatives demonstrate resilience and creativity in navigating oppression. Scholarly and advocacy work emphasizes the urgent need for decriminalization and inclusive policies to address these human rights violations. LGBTQ Zimbabweans endure systemic oppression but persist through covert activism, community solidarity, and transnational advocacy. Their experiences reflect both the brutality of structural violence and the resilience of marginalized communities forging dignity in hostile spaces.

1.2 Importance of studying personal experiences of LGBTQ individuals

The lived experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe are shaped by a historical legacy of colonial-era legislation, cultural conservatism, and systemic marginalization. Zimbabwe inherited its anti-LGBTQ laws from British colonial rule, notably through Section 73 of the Criminal Law Code, which criminalizes same-sex relations. This legal framework has been reinforced by decades of political rhetoric, including former President Robert Mugabe's infamous 1995 declaration that homosexuals were "worse than pigs and dogs," a sentiment echoed by his successor, Emmerson Mnangagwa, who has dismissed LGBTQ rights as incompatible with Zimbabwean "*values*." These laws and discourses have entrenched societal homophobia, positioning LGBTQ individuals as both legal and cultural outsiders.

Academic and advocacy work over the past decade highlights how this hostility manifests in daily life. For instance, studies by Muparamoto (2021) and GALZ (2020) revealed that LGBTQ+ Zimbabweans face pervasive discrimination, including familial rejection, workplace exclusion, and physical violence. However, much of this research predates 2022, leaving gaps in understanding contemporary dynamics, particularly in the wake of COVID-19, which exacerbated economic precarity and reduced access to safe social networks.

The study's urgency lies in documenting how systemic discrimination and prejudices intersects with individual agency in this fraught context. While existing scholarship focuses on legal frameworks or HIV-related vulnerabilities, fewer studies center personal narratives from 2022 onwards, when political tensions and economic instability (e.g., unemployment rates exceeded 90%) compounded LGBTQ marginalization. Furthermore, the role of digital spaces—both as sites of resistance and surveillance—remains under-explored in the Zimbabwean context.

1.3 Legal status of LGBTQ rights in Africa.

In Africa, individuals who identify as LGBTQ face unique challenges and discrimination due to cultural, religious and legal factors. Africa has 54 countries with vastly different legal frameworks, many anti-LGBTQ laws stem from British colonial penal codes, ranging from full criminalization to constitutional protections. South Africa stands out as a progressive exception with its post-apartheid constitution. The lived experiences of LGBTQ individuals across Africa reflect profound challenges shaped by legal hostility, societal stigma and institutional discrimination, even in jurisdiction with progressive legal frameworks. Simultaneously, quantitative legal analysis reveals stark disparities in decriminalization status. While progress has been made in some countries towards recognizing and protecting the rights of LGBTQ community, 32 nations in Africa still have laws criminalizing same-sex relationships, which sums up the prevalence of how homosexuality is an untold narrative in African setup systems. A systematic analysis reveals several key patterns:

1.3.1. Predominance of Criminalization.

Most African nations maintain laws criminalizing same-sex relations, primarily inherited from British colonial penal codes (notably Sections 377/378) and French anti-sodomy laws. At least 31 of Africa's 54 countries explicitly criminalize consensual same-sex conduct (ILGA World, 2023). Charges stem from monetary fines (e.g., Liberia) to life imprisonment (e.g., Tanzania, Uganda) and, in a few jurisdictions like Mauritania and Somalia (under Sharia law), even the death penalty (Amnesty International, 2022).

1.3.2 Constitutional Ambiguity and Progressive Exceptions.

South Africa stands as the stark exception, with a post-apartheid constitution (1996) explicitly prohibiting discrimination based on sexual orientation. This has enabled landmark rulings allowing same-sex marriage (2006) and adoption rights. Angola (2021), Mozambique (2015), and Botswana

(2019) have repealed colonial-era anti-homosexuality laws through legislative or judicial action. Botswana's Court of Appeal notably declared criminalization unconstitutional, asserting that *"the state has no business in the private lives of consenting adults"* (Motshidiemang v. Attorney General, 2021).

1.3.3 Legislative Backlash and "Anti-Homosexuality" Laws

Several nations have enacted/proposed laws intensifying penalties or criminalizing LGBTQ advocacy; at the top being Uganda's Anti-Homosexuality Act (2023) which imposes life imprisonment for "aggravated homosexuality" and criminalizes it. Similar bills have surfaced in Ghana, Kenya, and Tanzania (2021 "Proper Human Sexual Rights" Bill). These often reflect political maneuvering, religious conservatism (influenced by US evangelical groups), and diversionary tactics (Awondo, 2020).

1.3.4 Regional Human Rights Mechanisms

The African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights lacks explicit sexual orientation protections. However, the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights (ACHPR) adopted Resolution 275 (2014), condemning violence against persons based on sexual orientation. Implementation remains weak, with states like Kenya explicitly rejecting the resolution's applicability (Ndashe, 2017). The African Court has yet to rule substantively on LGBTQ rights; however, it condemns violence and discrimination based on sexual orientation and identity.

1.3.5 Emerging Trends and Activism

Grassroots LGBTQ organizations (e.g., GALZ in Zimbabwe, LEGABIBO in Botswana) increasingly challenge laws through strategic litigation. In 2023, Mauritius' Supreme Court decriminalized same-sex relations (Collectif Arc-En-Ciel v. State), citing privacy rights. Digital platforms have enabled transnational advocacy networks, though online surveillance creates new risks (Currier & Cruz, 2020). Africa's LGBTQ legal landscape reflects a tension between entrenched criminalization and incremental progress. While colonial legacies and politicized homophobia sustain repression, constitutional challenges and activist resilience are driving change in select jurisdictions. Research gaps persist regarding inter-sectional vulnerabilities (e.g., LGBTQ refugees, rural communities) and the impact of religious fundamentalism on legal reforms.

While global movements for gender and sexual diversity have gained momentum, Zimbabwe's government has doubled down on repression. Authorities censored Pride month events, raided LGBTQ gatherings, and amplified anti-LGBTQ rhetoric in state media. Simultaneously, grassroots organizations like GALZ and Trans Smart Trust intensified advocacy through digital platforms, despite risks of online harassment and surveillance. This period saw heightened transnational activism, with Zimbabwean LGBTQ refugees in South Africa drawing attention to intersecting crises of asylum, poverty, and health disparities (Macharia, 2022). Therefore, one can deduce that Zimbabwe, like other African countries still repress the legalization of homosexuality in the country, thus the constitution and the society prove this through use of rigorous mechanisms which are discriminatory to the LGBTQ members in the country.

This research seeks to address gaps by foregrounding firsthand accounts of LGBTQ Zimbabweans to date, interrogating how they navigate legal threats, cultural stigma, and economic survival. It situates their experiences within broader discourses of human rights, postcolonial identity, and resilience, contributing to interdisciplinary debates on queer liberation in hostile environments.

1.4 Statement of the problem

The problem addressed by this study centers on the systemic oppression faced by LGBTQ+ individuals in Zimbabwe, where state-sanctioned homophobia, sociocultural stigmatization, and legal violence converge to create an environment of profound marginalization. The persecution of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe constitutes a severe human rights crisis, yet their lived experiences remain critically understudied, obscuring the nuances of their agency and resistance amid systemic oppression. Despite decades of advocacy and limited qualitative research documenting lived experiences, Zimbabwe retains colonial-era laws criminalizing same-sex relations (Section 73 of the Criminal Law Code), which institutionalize discrimination and fuel societal violence. This legal framework, compounded by political scapegoating and cultural stigma, creates intersecting vulnerabilities for LGBTQ individuals, affecting their safety, health, and socioeconomic survival. The study sought to offer a comprehensive understanding on the day-to-day livelihoods of the LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe. The need to explore the attitudes and normative patterns surrounding the LGBTQ members and how it relates to the heteronormative patterns of the society dissect into bringing about the relevance of this study. However, three core research gaps persist:

1.4.1 Invisibility of Contemporary Realities.

Existing scholarship (Epprecht, 2013; Muparamoto, 2021) predominantly analyzed pre-2020 dynamics, failing to capture how recent socio-political shifts—such as intensified state repression during Mnangagwa’s regime, economic collapse (95% unemployment in 2022), and the aftermath of COVID-19—exacerbate LGBTQ marginalization. For instance, state crackdowns on civil society in 2022 led to increased police raids on safe spaces, yet documented testimonies of these incidents are sparse (Amnesty International, 2023).

1.4.2 Epistemic Erasure of Resilience.

Narratives foregrounding victimhood eclipse community-led resistance. While studies highlight discrimination (GALZ, 2020), they seldom examine how LGBTQ Zimbabweans utilize digital tools, art, or transnational networks for survival. A 2022 survey by Trans Smart Trust revealed that 68% of transgender respondents used encrypted apps for peer support, but scholarly attention to such adaptive strategies remains minimal.

1.4.3 Intersectional Data Deficits.

Research often homogenizes LGBTQ experiences, neglecting how gender identity, class, and location compound oppression. Rural LGBTQ youth, for example, face heightened isolation due to limited internet access and conservative kinship structures, yet no data quantifies this disparity (Mhiripiri, 2022). Similarly, the exclusion of same-sex couples from Zimbabwe’s HIV prevention programs—despite their heightened viral vulnerability—lacks focused analysis. This study addresses gaps by interrogating how LGBTQ Zimbabweans navigate oppression while forging resilience. It challenges academic complicity in epistemic erasure and advocates for actionable, intersectional policy reforms.

1.5 Study Objectives

1. To investigate and understand the challenges and discrimination faced by LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe and trace which opportunities are available for them?
2. To explore the impact of societal norms, cultural beliefs, and legal frameworks on the lives of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe.
3. To identify the coping mechanisms, support systems, and resilience factors that contribute to the wellbeing and empowerment of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe.

1.7 Research Questions

1. What are the forms of discrimination faced by LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe?
2. How do societal norms, cultural beliefs and legal regulations influence the lived experiences of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe?
3. What are the coping strategies and support systems utilized by LGBTQ individuals to navigate the social environment in Zimbabwe?
4. How do personal experiences of stigma and discrimination impact the mental health and well-being of LGBTQ individual in Zimbabwe?

1.8 Scope of the study

The research will focus on gathering qualitative data through interviews from LGBTQ individuals living in Zimbabwe. The study will explore challenges, discrimination, coping mechanisms and support systems within the cultural, social and legal context of Zimbabwe. The research will examine the implications of personal experiences on the mental health and well-being of LGBTQ individuals in the societies. Additionally, the study will seek to provide insights and recommendations for promoting inclusivity, acceptance and empowerment of the LGBTQ community in Zimbabwe.

2. Literature Review

This chapter reveals a complex landscape of reported systemic oppression, resilience, and evolving social dynamics among the LGBTQ in Zimbabwe. Previous studies have highlighted how colonial-era laws, notably Section 73 of the Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act intersects with socio-cultural norms to perpetuate marginalization among the LGBTQ members in Zimbabwe (Muparamoto, 2021). The legal and socio-political landscape for LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe is characterized by systemic persecution rooted in colonial legacies, reinforced by post-independence political rhetoric, and compounded by conservative socio-religious norms. This context fundamentally shapes the lived experiences documented in contemporary research to date.

2.1 Definition of LGBTQ

LGBTQ is an acronym that stands for Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender and Queer which refers to sexual orientation, gender identity or expression of an individual. In other words, these are individuals who engage in same-sex relationships, and those whose gender identity differs from sex assigned from birth. Some individuals transition from male to female (mtf) or from female to male (ftm) to align their bodies with their gender identity. Legalization of LGBTQ in most African countries remains an unexplained narrative of today's world. There is strong public aversion towards the acceptance of LGBTQ community, as many African countries are guided by the laws of cultural and societal norms. It is assumed that statistically over 70 countries criminalize homosexuality as a chosen sexuality which goes against the ethics of many governed nations thereby is abolished. Debates surrounding the decriminalization of LGBTQ identities have consistently been a prominent issue within Zimbabwe's constitutional framework. LGBTQ individuals are often ridiculed and subjected to derogatory name-calling, which consequently discourages them from openly expressing their identities.

The common local terminology used to describe individuals of diverse sexual orientations are 'ngochani' (referring to lesbian women) and 'ngito' (a derogatory term for gay men)". The names all objectify and ridicule LGBTQ community members to a minimal stupor level of humanity, such that there is sporadic incidence of physical violence, discrimination, extortion and psychological abuse of people that identify as LGBTQ. Among the thirty-two countries in Africa that criminalize homosexuality, Zimbabwe is still at the core of criminalizing same-sex

relationships. Scholars have argued that what criminalizes homosexuality is the societal perceptions that people exhibit towards LGBTQ members, rather than its legal implications.

2.2 Theoretical Framework: Minority Stress Theory

This theory, developed by Meyer (2003) in the context of sexual minorities, posits that individuals who belong to stigmatized minority groups experience unique stressors that can impact their mental health and well-being. Meyer's Minority Stress Theoretical (MST) framework purports that LGBTQ individuals face both distal stressors (external factors such as discrimination, prejudice, and violence) and proximal stressors (internal factors such as internalized homophobia, concealment of identity, and identity management) that contribute to increased levels of psychological distress. Zimbabwe's LGBTQ persons face the reality of this theory starting from the structural violence purported by the legal persecution; the existence of the Criminal codification and reform Act alone which criminalizes same-sex relations creates an environment of state-sanctioned stigma. The theory further aligns its justification on how political leaders rhetorically weaponizes cultural nationalism, framing homosexuality as 'un-African,' thereby intensifying societal hostility. This institutionalized homophobia generates distal stressors (like arrests, violence, job loss) central to MST.

Applying the MST to the personal experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe, researcher seek to explore how the intersection of societal stigma, legal restrictions, and cultural norms create stressors that influence their mental health, social relationships, and overall quality of life. Experiences are not monolithic, research by Muparamoto (2021) demonstrates how factors like gender identity, socioeconomic status, and location compound stress. Transgender individuals and gender non-conforming men face heightened visibility and violence from fellow men denouncing homosexuality as disrespect to *paternal domiciliary*. Understanding how these stressors manifest and interact will aid or inform interventions and support systems that may promote resilience and well-being among LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe.

Crucially, scholars emphasize agency and resistance within the hostile context; Chigwedere (2019) and Matebeni (2014) documents '*survivalist adaptations*' arguing that in an environment where stigmatization and discrimination is rampant it is advised to sought adaptation skills that aligns with societal expectations. Ekine (2013) argues that western-centrism MST models must be

adapted to recognize these uniquely African forms of resilience and community building under duress, which mitigate the impact of chronic stresses.

However, some scholars caution against over applying MST without contextual sensitivity. This is so because Tamale (2013), noted that western identity labels of LGBTQ may not fully capture the local African sexual/gender diversities or indigenous understanding of same-sex relations. Furthermore, focusing solely on pathology risks obscuring everyday forms of resistance and joy, thus by grounding the study in the MST, the researcher will be able to analyze the structural and interpersonal challenges faced by LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe, shedding light on the complexities of their experiences and advocating for policies and practices that foster inclusive and support for the marginalized community.

2.3 Zimbabwe LGBTQ Laws

Zimbabwe maintains some of Africa's most restrictive and explicitly homophobic laws concerning LGBTQ individuals, deeply entrenched within its legal framework and political rhetoric. The cornerstone is Section 78 of the Constitution of Zimbabwe (CoZ) (2013), which explicitly defines marriage as exclusively between "a man and a woman," effectively precluding legal recognition of same-sex unions or partnerships and setting a discriminatory constitutional tone. More pervasively, consensual same-sex sexual conduct between men remains criminalized under Sections 73 and 77 of the Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act (Chapter 9:23). Section 73 prohibits "sodomy" (defined as anal sexual intercourse), punishable by fines and up to one year imprisonment, or more if aggravating factors exist. Section 77 prohibits "any act involving physical contact... that would be regarded by a reasonable person as an indecent act," interpreted to encompass a broad range of same-sex intimate conduct.

Critically, the 2006 Criminal Law Amendment introduced "aggravated indecency" provisions specifically targeting same-sex conduct between men, women, or between human and animal, carrying potential sentences of up to 10 years imprisonment, significantly harsher than penalties for comparable heterosexual acts classified as simple "indecency" (Human Rights Watch, "Criminalizing Identities", 2022). These laws are reinforced by the Censorship and Entertainments Control Act, often used to suppress LGBTQ advocacy materials under obscenity clauses.

Zimbabwe's anti-LGBTQ laws originate from British colonial penal codes, notably Sections 73 and 77 of the Criminal Law (Codification and Reform) Act (Epprecht, 2019). The abolition of LGBTQ dates way before independence as seen by archaic heritage books and culture were no records of same-sex relationships or entanglements have been recorded ever. It is for this reason that LGBTQ persons have faced significant societal and legal prejudice over the years. Former Zimbabwean president regarded and weaponized homophobia as a tool of nationalist ideology, publicly declaring LGBTQ identities demonic and aligning them with Western imperialism (Msibi, 2021). This politicized homophobia entrenched societal stigma, framing queer existence as a threat to cultural values. Zimbabwe through socialization has not accepted LGBTQ identities and socially is justified by norms and values which defines the correct sexual identity an individual should identify as while living in Zimbabwe.

The legal hostility is amplified by sustained political homophobia, epitomized by former President Robert Mugabe's infamous public denunciations of homosexuality as "un-African," "unnatural," and "worse than dogs and pigs," creating a climate of state-sanctioned stigma. Judicial interpretations have consistently upheld this repression. The 1996 Supreme Court case (*State v Canaan Banana*) (though focused on non-consensual acts) reinforced the criminal status of sodomy. In (*Kanane v The State*, 2004), the Supreme Court rejected a constitutional challenge to Sections 73 and 77, declaring societal "*revulsion*" justified criminalization and that decriminalization was a matter for parliament, not the courts. Consequently, LGBTQ individuals face pervasive discrimination, harassment, violence, extortion ("blackmail"), and significant barriers to healthcare, employment, and housing, with authorities failing to protect them (GALZ, "Human Rights Violations Report", 2021).

While arrests solely for private, consensual adult same-sex conduct under Sections 73/77 appear less frequent in recent years, the existence of these laws provides a constant threat, facilitates police abuse (including arbitrary arrests under public order or nuisance laws), and legitimizes societal discrimination. The legal framework actively suppresses LGBTQ organizing, with groups like Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe (GALZ) operating under constant threat and facing registration denials. Scholars like Marc Epprecht ("*Heterosexual Africa?*", 2008) and Tinashe Chimedza ("*The State, Homosexuality and the Politics of Moral Outrage in Zimbabwe*") argue this legal architecture stems from a potent mix of colonial-era penal codes retained post-independence,

instrumentalized political homophobia to deflect from governance failures and mobilize conservative constituencies, and complex engagements with contested notions of culture and nationalism. This creates an environment where fundamental rights to privacy, equality, nondiscrimination, freedom of expression, and association for LGBTQ Zimbabweans are systematically denied.

Zimbabwe's cultural perspective on LGBTQ identities is predominantly shaped by a confluence of political rhetoric, religious conservatism, colonial legacies, and selective interpretations of tradition. Unlike some African nations where decriminalization has occurred, Zimbabwe maintains one of the continent's most hostile environments, institutionalized through law and amplified by state-sponsored homophobia. Similarly, in other conservative contexts such as Lebanon, citizens remain opposed to the acceptance of LGBTQ people into society, viewing LGBTQ people as psychologically or medically defective and a threat to traditional heteropatriarchal values, thereby normalizing harassment and discrimination against LGBTQ individuals, even within healthcare facilities Girijashanker (2008).

2.3.1 Political Weaponization of Homophobia.

The political strata of Zimbabwe during Mugabe's leadership since 1980 when Zimbabwe attained its independence was vehemently against the LGBTQ community that to date most of Mugabe's Legacy followers uses politics to bash the pride members. Former President Robert Mugabe (1980–2017) famously declared homosexuality "worse than dogs and pigs" and a "white disease" incompatible with African values. This rhetoric fused nationalism with homophobia, positioning LGBTQ rights as a colonial import (Epprecht, 2008). This ongoing State Hostility by political leaders is evidenced today by current leaders including President Mnangagwa, who publicly reject LGBTQ rights, framing them as threats to "family values." Zimbabwe's laws (Sections 73–74 of the Criminal Code) criminalize same-sex intimacy with penalties up to three years imprisonment. However, of late, due to political strife where leaders are focused on the nation other agendas, homosexuals are gaining confidence of expressing themselves as little or less discrimination or arrests are observed since the inception of Mnangagwa. This poses a question whether the current government is turning a blind eye on homosexuality or it is feigning ignorance on the matter.

2.3.2 Sociocultural and Religious Dimensions.

Religious Conservatism in Zimbabwe is centred on communal perceptions and beliefs. Over 85% of Zimbabweans identify as Christians (Afrobarometer, 2022), with Apostolic sects and evangelical groups condemning homosexuality as "sinful." Moreover, traditional leaders (e.g., chiefs) align with churches, invoking ancestral customs against LGBTQ visibility (Muparamoto, 2021) stipulating it as a shame to the ancestors and a rotten womb of the mother that bore the child. The existence of selective traditionalism evokes the notion of pre-colonial Shona/Ndebele cultures which recognize gender-diverse roles like "*n'anga*" (healers), except for same-sex relationships which were rarely documented. Contemporary homophobia misrepresents history by erasing fluid pre-colonial identities (Nycek, 2016).

2.3.3 Lived Realities: Stigma and Resistance

Violence and Exclusion: A 2023 GALZ (Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe) report documented 65% of LGBTQ+ individuals experiencing familial rejection, 40% facing workplace discrimination, and 30% enduring physical violence. This persecution is said to be effective once an individual discloses their sexual orientation. Thereby, many have acknowledged to be living in hiding for fear of discrimination. Transgender Zimbabweans face heightened risks, with no legal gender recognition. The society of today now disguise through fashion networking, dressing openly disguising as social media influencers; the trend of cross-dressing is noted as marketing businesses strategy (e.g. MamaVee, Shatrisha, Titi waMaiTT, Chihwachehugune, Dr. Matigimu, etc).

Their sexual orientation has been questioned as to whether it aligns with what resonates with our cultural values and norms. Many have been bashed on social media networks as their self-acclaimed business strategies involves cross-dressing a key feature of what LGBTQ members are known for. Despite this repression, organizations like GALZ provide legal aid and protection to members who seek their aid. Queer activists use digital platforms for advocacy, though they risk arrest under cyber laws (Duri, 2022). Art and literature (e.g., filmmaker Tapiwa Chipfupa) have become subversive tools for visibility.

2.4 Plight of LGBTQ Persons in Africa

The personal experiences of LGBTQ individuals across Africa are characterized by profound heterogeneity, shaped by intersecting factors of colonial legacies, legal frameworks cultural

diversity, and localized resistance. With 32 African nations criminalizing same-sex relations, Africa has seen at forefront Uganda's 2023 Anti-Homosexuality Act, Nigeria's same sex Marriage Prohibition Act as the dominant sign of local resistance to homosexuality which they regard as western influence on Africa. Contrastingly, South Africa (1996), Angola (2019), Botswana (2019), and Mozambique (2015) have decriminalized homosexuality, though implementation gaps persist through discrimination and homophobia antics. Therefore, with Africa's vastly different legal and social landscapes has seen legal hostility forces forcing LGBTQ individuals into secrecy, police brutality and healthcare exclusion (ILGA World Report, 2023).

The plight of LGBTQ individuals is characterized by systematic persecution, legal criminalization, and sociocultural erasure, creating a landscape of profound vulnerability. In most African countries generally, there is assumption that belonging to the LGBTQ community is a sign of deviant behaviour that should be forsaken as it pollutes the masses of the community. Ugandan minister was once quoted arguing that, *"It is a learned behaviour and can be unlearned. You can't tell me people are born gays. It is foreign influence at work."* Such connotation according to the minister implied that as Africans it is wholly unheard of to being gay, as it juxtaposed what Durkheim noted on deviant behaviour in the society (Durkheim, 1962). To Durkheim, deviant behaviour is constructive behaviour that served a normalcy for the crucial functioning of the society, thereby in an African setup LGBTQ came as a form of deviant behaviour that the LGBTQ community expresses as the one that serves fulfilment of certain individuals' contentment.

2.4.1 The Complex Landscape of LGBTQ+ Rights and Realities in Southern Africa.

Southern Africa has a profound and often contradictory landscape regarding LGBTQ rights and lived experiences, characterized by a stark tension between progressive constitutional frameworks in some nations and deeply entrenched societal homophobia and trans-phobia across the region. South Africa stands as a global anomaly, boasting one of the world's most progressive constitutions since 1996, explicitly prohibiting discrimination based on sexual orientation. This led to landmark legal victories, including the legalization of same-sex marriage in 2006. However, this legal protection starkly contrasts with the pervasive reality of violence, discrimination, and social stigma. Hate crimes, particularly the horrific phenomenon of "corrective rape" targeting Black lesbian women, remains alarmingly common, reflecting a deep societal resistance fueled by patriarchal norms, conservative religious interpretations, and persistent harmful stereotypes. As Nel and Judge

(2008) documented, many LGBTQ+ South Africans live in a state of "double consciousness," aware of their constitutional rights yet constantly navigating fear and danger in daily life.

Beyond South Africa, the regional picture becomes significantly more precarious. Several countries retain colonial-era penal codes criminalizing consensual same-sex sexual conduct. While Botswana's High Court decriminalized homosexuality in 2019 (a ruling upheld by the Court of Appeal in 2021), and Angola decriminalized in 2021, countries like Namibia (despite recent court challenges), Zimbabwe, Zambia, and Malawi maintain laws that render same-sex relationships illegal, often punishable by imprisonment. These laws, even if inconsistently enforced, legitimize discrimination, inhibit access to essential services like healthcare (particularly vital in the context of HIV/AIDS), and create a climate of fear and secrecy for LGBTQ individuals. Social attitudes remain overwhelmingly negative. A 2016 Afrobarometer survey found majorities in most Southern African countries believed homosexuality should not be tolerated by society, reflecting the influence of conservative religious and cultural norms. Transgender and gender-diverse individuals face particularly acute marginalization, often lacking legal recognition and facing significant barriers to healthcare and employment.

The situation is further complicated by intersecting vulnerabilities, including poverty, high HIV prevalence, and gender-based violence, which disproportionately impact LGBTQ communities, especially those in townships and rural areas. NGOs and activists across the region, such as LEGABIBO in Botswana and Iranti in South Africa, work tirelessly against immense opposition to challenge discriminatory laws, provide support services, and shift societal attitudes, representing crucial agents of change amidst this complex and often hostile environment (Currier & Cruz, 2021).

Zimbabwe's cultural stance is not monolithic but defined by state-sponsored hostility, religious rigidity, and grassroots resilience. Tsitsi Dangarembga observed in Selvick (2012), *"The struggle for queer rights is inseparable from Zimbabwe's broader fight for democracy."* With Christianity and traditional beliefs strong across the continent, it is common to hear homosexuality denounced as "un-African" or an import of western immorality.", for instance '*Nigeria's Save Africa from Homosexuality*' campaign weaponize faith to justify violence on individuals who identified as homosexuals (Klinken, 2021). Zimbabwe further noted (Nuwa, 2020) 68% of LGBTQ Zimbabweans experience familial violence or homelessness upon disclosure from society, thus new laws like Freedom of Information Act (2020) were introduced offering protection on sexual

orientation to individuals identifying as LGBTQ. Kinship ties in socio-cultural respective hinge on conformity, forcing many into sham heterosexual marriages or exile. Hence it is a huge disparity at any point in Zimbabwe to accept homosexuality as a gender normative.

2.4.2 The Repressive Landscape of LGBTQ+ Rights in East Africa: Persecution, Politics, and Resilience.

East Africa is one of the most hostile environments for LGBTQ individuals globally, characterized by near-universal criminalization, intense societal stigma driven by political manipulation and conservative religious forces, and severe human rights violations. Unlike in Southern Africa, where South Africa offers constitutional protections, no East African nation provides legal recognition or comprehensive safeguards for sexual and gender minorities. Colonial-era penal codes, particularly versions of the British anti-sodomy laws (e.g., Sections 162-165 of the Kenyan Penal Code, Sections 145 and 146 of the Ugandan Penal Code), remain firmly entrenched and actively enforced, rendering consensual same-sex relations illegal and punishable by lengthy prison sentences – up to life imprisonment in Tanzania. This legal persecution creates a pervasive climate of fear.

Uganda as the extremist country in East Africa, enacted the draconian Anti-Homosexuality Act (AHA) in 2023, which imposed the death penalty for "aggravated homosexuality" and harsh prison terms for mere identification as LGBTQ or "promotion" of homosexuality. This law was heavily influenced by US evangelical groups (Kaoma, 2013), and has led to a surge in arrests, torture, evictions, vigilante violence, and a collapse in access to essential healthcare, particularly for HIV prevention and treatment (Human Rights Watch, 2024). Kenya, with its mandate on equality for all dectum, still criminalizes same-sex conduct under its Penal Code. Authorities frequently subject LGBTQ individuals to arbitrary arrests, extortion, and police brutality, often leveraging vague "public morality" statutes (Amnesty International, 2023).

Societal attitudes across East Africa are overwhelmingly negative, fueled by a potent mix of politicized homophobia, where leaders scapegoat LGBTQ communities to divert attention from governance failures and rally conservative constituencies, and deeply ingrained conservative interpretations of Christianity and Islam. Politicians and religious leaders routinely deploy dehumanizing rhetoric, labeling LGBTQ individuals as "un-African," "immoral," or a threat to societal fabric. This rhetoric directly incites violence and discrimination, forcing individuals into

hiding, destroying family relationships, and leading to job losses and homelessness. Tanzania under President Magufuli intensified crackdowns, banning HIV outreach organizations serving key populations and conducting violent raids on perceived LGBTQ gatherings. While Seychelles decriminalized same-sex relations in 2016, societal hostility remains high. Rwanda stands as a relative anomaly by not actively enforcing its colonial-era anti-sodomy law and refusing to enact harsher legislation despite pressure, though discrimination persists. Transgender and intersex individuals face compounded vulnerabilities, lacking legal recognition and facing immense barriers to healthcare and safety.

The criminalization environment severely undermines public health efforts, driving LGBTQ individuals underground and away from vital HIV/AIDS services and other healthcare, exacerbating the epidemic. Despite this brutal context, courageous local activists and organizations, such as the National Gay and Lesbian Human Rights Commission (NGLHRC) in Kenya and Sexual Minorities Uganda (SMUG), engage in relentless legal battles, provide clandestine support services, and document abuses, facing immense personal risk and operating under constant threat of closure or arrest (Tamale, 2013; Awondo et al., 2012).

2.4.3 The Complex Terrain of LGBTQ+ Rights in West Africa: Criminalization, Social Hostility, and Fragile Resistance.

West Africa is particularly severe and complex environment for LGBTQ individuals, characterized by near-universal criminalization, intense societal hostility often fueled by religious and political leaders, and increasingly draconian legislation, though marked by nuanced variations and pockets of resilience. Unlike Southern Africa, there are no constitutional safe havens here. Colonial-era penal codes criminalizing "carnal knowledge against the order of nature" or "acts of gross indecency" (inherited from British and French legal systems) remain in force and are actively enforced across most of the region.

Nigeria exemplifies the extreme end of this spectrum. Its 2014 Same-Sex Marriage Prohibition Act (SSMPA) not only bans same-sex unions but also criminalizes the mere public display of same-sex affection, participation in LGBTQ+ groups, and even the provision of services or safe spaces, imposing penalties of up to 10-14 years' imprisonment. This law has fostered an environment of state-sanctioned persecution, leading to mass arrests, torture, extortion by police, mob violence, pervasive blackmail, and widespread societal expulsion (ILGA World, 2023;

Human Rights Watch, 2016). Similarly, Senegal, a predominantly Muslim nation, enforces Article 319 of its penal code, punishing "unnatural acts" with up to five years in prison, often incited by powerful religious leaders framing homosexuality as un-Islamic and un-African, leading to frequent arrests and vigilante attacks (Longman, 2020).

Ghana has a critical battleground, with a highly controversial and internationally condemned "Proper Human Sexual Rights and Ghanaian Family Values Bill" currently pending. This proposed legislation mirrors Nigeria's SSMPA in its severity, seeking to criminalize LGBTQ identity, advocacy, allyship, and funding, while promoting harmful "conversion therapy" and imposing harsher sentences. Its potential passage has already intensified stigma, violence, and forced displacement within the LGBTQ+ community (Amnesty International, 2023).

The social landscape across West Africa is overwhelmingly hostile. Deeply conservative interpretations of Islam (in Sahelian and coastal nations) and rapidly growing evangelical Christianity (particularly in Ghana and Nigeria) powerfully shape public opinion, often conflating LGBTQ identities with Western cultural imperialism and moral decay. Politicians frequently exploit this sentiment, framing anti-LGBTQ rhetoric as a defense of "African values" and national sovereignty. This pervasive homophobia and transphobia translate into devastating daily realities: familial rejection, homelessness, employment discrimination, violent assaults, and fatal mob attacks, often with impunity for perpetrators. Access to healthcare, particularly HIV prevention and treatment for key populations, is severely hampered by fear of exposure and criminalization.

Transgender individuals face extreme marginalization, lacking legal recognition and facing immense barriers to transition-related care and safety. Only Cape Verde stands as a partial exception, having decriminalized same-sex relations in 2004, though societal acceptance remains limited. Despite this oppressive environment, courageous local activists and organizations (e.g., The Initiative for Equal Rights TIERS in Nigeria, LGBTQ+ Rights Ghana) engage in perilous work – documenting abuses, providing clandestine support, challenging laws in domestic and regional courts like the ECOWAS Court of Justice, and leveraging digital platforms for advocacy, often operating under constant threat of arrest, violence, or closure (Dankwa, 2021; Sall, 2018). Their resilience underscores the ongoing struggle for dignity and rights in one of the world's most challenging regions for sexual and gender minorities.

2.5 Conclusion: A Paradox of visibility

Zimbabwe's LGBTQ community exists in a double bind, that expression or "coming out" as they call it stipulates visibility which invites violence, while invisibility enables erasure. Their plight underscores the failure of the postcolonial state to protect marginalized citizens, yet their resilience epitomizes what S. Tamale (2020) called "*radical re-existence*" which implies surviving not despite the state, but beyond it. Sustainable change requires centering grassroots voices in policy reform and challenging the colonial roots of homophobic legislation, thus organizations like GALZ operate with the hope that at one point the government will legalize homosexuality and recognize their rights.

3 Methodology

This study used qualitative research design which allowed to explore and understand lived experiences of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe. According to George (2023), research methodology discusses and explains the data collection and analysis used in research thus this chapter outlined the data collection methods and analysis tools which were used. Research on lived experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe will require a methodology grounded in interpretive approach, which prioritize ethical rigor, cultural contextualization and participant safety. Given the criminalization of same-sex relations (Criminal Law Codification Act, Section 73) and pervasive sociopolitical hostility, methodological choices will be centered on minimizing harm while capturing nuanced realities.

3.1 Research Philosophy

An in-depth qualitative assessment of the study will be used in getting an in-depth understanding on the lived experiences and living mechanisms used by members of the LGBTQ while living in Zimbabwe where homosexuality is seen as a derogatory act of sodomy and a sign of deviant behaviour in the society. Delve (2024) argued that *“In-depth interviews are a cornerstone of qualitative research, especially in approaches like grounded theory and ethnography”* where understanding the nuances of personal experiences are key to developing rich, grounded theories. Therefore, structured approach will ensure a comprehensive understanding of the personal experiences of LGBTQ+ community members in Zimbabwe. The study will deploy an interview methodology which aides in consecrating data for the purpose of establishing a rapport on lived experiences of LGBTQ+ members in Zimbabwe.

3.2 Population

The researcher focused on any respondents of Zimbabwean nationality residing in the country who identified as LGBTQ. According to GALZ (Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe), the statistics regarding the number of LGBTQ members in Zimbabwe are constantly evolving and can be challenging to accurately quantify due to social stigma and legal restrictions. However, GALZ estimates suggested that there is a significant LGBTQ population in Zimbabwe, with many

individuals' facing discrimination and persecution based on their sexual orientation or gender identity. While specific numerical data may be difficult to ascertain, it is essential to recognize the existence of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe and the importance of advocating for their rights and well-being. By acknowledging and supporting the LGBTQ community, we can work towards creating a more inclusive and accepting society for all homosexual individuals in Zimbabwe.

3.3 Sampling

The sampling eligibility criteria was limited to persons 18 years of age to who: (1) identified as lesbian, gay, bisexual, or transgender and queer; (2) are citizens or residents of Zimbabwe. As data collection was based on snowballing and referral methodology most of the participants participated after the referral. The research fell under the key populations research category and adopted a sampling strategy to recruit participants which was of key importance as it followed the ethical guidelines of key populations. The research adopted snowball sampling.

Snowballing is defined as the practise of soliciting a possible or existing participant to recommend another potential participant, who subsequently refers another (Atkinson & Flint, 2001; Kuper, Lingard, & Levinson, 2008). Snowballing sampling, applied to the research on LGBTQ populations in Zimbabwe represents a critical methodological strategy born of necessity in contexts of extreme social stigma and criminalization. This non-probability sampling technique operated in locating respondents who were interviewed on the telephonic interviews and one on one interviews done on Microsoft Teams through participant-driven referrals, where initial '*seed*' participants recruited others from their social networks, expanding chains of respondents. The first respondents were provided by GALZ and PAKASIPITI which are LGBTQ organizations in Zimbabwe and then they referred other participants who were also willing to take part in the research until data saturation was reached.

Given Zimbabwe's criminalization of same-sex relations (Section 73) and pervasive societal homophobia, LGBT individuals form a hidden population with no sampling frame, thereby snowballing bypasses this by leveraging existing trust networks. Researchers like Muparamoto (2021), Chigwedere (2019) relied on initial contacts from LGBT support organizations (GALZ) to identify '*seeds*' who then referred peers' confidentiality. This method accesses communities that fear public visibility, thus enabling ethical-practical balancing act of observing anonymity and trust building protocols.

However, according to Muparamoto (2021) this technique will suffer network homogeneity and hierarchy reinforcements, as snowballing mostly captures clustered subgroups only (urban middle-class LGBT individuals), under-representing rural, low-income or isolated populations, thus referral chains may privilege well-connected individuals, silencing marginalized voices within the LGBT community for instance, transgender sex workers.

Snowball sampling remains indispensable for studying Zimbabwean LGBTQ communities offering unparalleled access to concealed experiences. When rigorously deployed, it not only generates data but also documents the resilience of social networks under oppression revealing how marginalized communities navigate invisibility as both a survival strategy and a site of resistance. However, its limitations necessitate methodological transparency and hybrid approaches.

3.5 Data Collection Instruments

The researcher used in-depth interviews to collect data, which were conducted via telephonic calls (WhatsApp) and Microsoft teams for a few individuals.

3.5.1 In-depth Interviews

Data were collected through comprehensive one-on-one interviews and telephonic interviews using in-depth interview guide. This method allowed for flexibility in probing deeper into participants' responses while maintaining a consistent structure to gather comparable data across interviews. With participants' permission, all interviews were audio-recorded to ensure accuracy in capturing their narratives, as well as for transcription and analysis.

The interview followed a semi structured format guided by an interview protocol (see **Appendix 2**). The interview guide consisted of open-ended questions organised into thematic areas including participants' daily experiences as LGBTQ persons in Zimbabwe, disclosure of identity, family, cultural and religious experiences, the impact of laws and policies, access to healthcare and authorities, mental health and well-being, support systems, and the use of digital spaces for connection and safety. The semi-structured nature of the interviews allowed the researcher to ask follow-up and probing questions where necessary to gain deeper insight and clarification on participants lived experiences while maintaining consistency across interviews.

The researcher conducted 18 interviews in total with members of the LGBTQ community. The researcher tried to capture the lived experiences representatives of the LGBTQ persons to ensure representation across different categories within the community. Interviews lasted approximately 15-30 minute. Most interviews were conducted through WhatsApp voice calls due to accessibility, participant preference, and convenience, while a smaller number of interviews were conducted through Microsoft Teams for participants who preferred that platform or had better access to it. Given the sensitive nature of the study, interviews were conducted when participants were in private and comfortable environments to ensure safety, confidentiality, and openness during discussions.

3.5.2 Data Collection Procedure

The researcher approached Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe (GALZ), a voluntary membership-based organization established to promote, protect, and represent the rights and interests of the LGBTQI community in Zimbabwe. GALZ was able to refer to some individuals who were comfortable to be part of the research study. From the few cases given, the researcher managed to come up with more research participants as they referred to other participants who were also willing to take part. The researcher then spoke to the participants and reviewed with them what the research was about and how data will be collected.

Online consent forms were given to the research participants before the interviews so that they could read and understand what the research will entail. They signed the consent forms to show that they had read and understood the contents. The researcher also took the time to explain to the research participants what the consent form entails in the language they best understood to avoid misinformation. The researcher explained to the participants that they could decide to withdraw from the interview at any given time and that the information they shared with the researcher would be kept confidential and destroyed after the research project was finished.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

The research being a sensitive topic required to exercise safety protocols such as anonymity. This must be absolute (e.g., pseudonyms, avoiding location-specific details). Recruitment occurred via trusted LGBTQ member organizations selected via criterion sampling (e.g., *GALZ*). Researcher acknowledged their own positionality (*outsider/insider status, privilege*) to avoid epistemic

violence (Tamale, 2020). Informed Consent, continuous consent processes (verbal/written) adapted for low-literacy contexts will be observed as the ethical and secure collection of personal experiences requires a meticulously planned protocol.

3.6.1 Informed Consent: Obtaining truly informed consent is a complex process, especially with vulnerable participants. The researcher ensured that individuals fully understood the risks of their participation, or social stigma. Consent must be voluntary and non-coerced, with participants having the ability to withdraw at any time without negative consequences.

3.6.2 Confidentiality and Anonymization: A fundamental principle was to protect the identity of participants at all costs. This required the use of robust anonymization protocols, including the use of pseudonyms and the removal of all personally identifiable information from transcripts and audio files. All data was stored and managed securely to prevent unauthorized access. Only the researcher had access to the audio files, and these were deleted when the research was concluded.

3.6.3 Data Storage and Access Control: Raw data was accessible and limited to the researcher, with clear protocols for data transfer and eventual destruction.

3.7 Data Analysis Framework for research on LGBT Experiences in Zimbabwe.

This research employed a critical interpretive approach combining thematic analysis and narrative inquiry. The methodology was designed to centre participant agency while navigating Zimbabwe's criminalization context, drawing on the reflective thematic analysis approach of Braun & Clarke (2006), narrative inquiry approaches by Riessman (2008), and the decolonizing adaption framework proposed Chigwedere (2021).

Following data collection, recorded interviews were transcribed to maintain accuracy during data transcription. The researcher carefully went through the data transcription to understand the content and look for ideas, meanings and concepts that would enable the researcher to understand participants' experiences. The initial coding involved identifying key words, phrases and recurring experiences across participants' accounts.

Thematic analysis was also adopted in the process of data analysis since it helped in the identification of themes and patterns in the experiences reported by the participants. Codes were

grouped into broader themes relevant to the research objectives, which included participants' experience with identity disclosure, family and religious influence, discrimination, health access and well-being, mental health, support systems and coping mechanisms. These themes were continuously reviewed and refined to ensure they accurately reflected participants' experiences.

In addition, narrative inquiry was employed to capture participants' personal narratives and the meaning that they attached to their experiences. Instead of confining participant's responses only to classification purposes, narrative inquiry allowed the researcher to explore how participants made sense of their life experiences in the social, cultural and legal contexts of Zimbabwe.

To promote contextually informed and sensitive analysis, the researcher adopted a decolonizing stance during data analysis. This helped to acknowledge the local context and avoid an excessive focus on western theory in explaining the life experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe.

4 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION: PERSONAL EXPERIENCES OF LGBTQ COMMUNITY MEMBERS IN ZIMBABWE

This chapter presents the findings obtained from the interview questions, which sought to understand the personal experiences of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe. Drawing on the literature review, the framework used in this study guided the analysis of the results and the discussion of the findings. The discussion is informed by existing literature and focuses on identifying similarities and differences in the everyday experiences faced by LGBTQ individuals. While awareness and acceptance of homosexuality are gradually increasing in some parts of the world, the situation remains different in many African countries, including Zimbabwe.

Several themes emerged as the researcher sought to understand the lived experiences of LGBTQ community members in a context where homosexuality is criminalized and culturally regarded as a taboo. These themes provide insight into the challenges, perceptions, and realities faced by LGBTQ individuals in their daily lives in Zimbabwe.

4.1 RESEARCH SAMPLE CHARACTERISTICS

The study comprised a total of 18 participants aged between 18 and 35 years. Participants were selected from diverse sexual orientation and gender identity groups which are lesbians, gays, transgender and intersex persons. This was done to obtain varied perspectives relevant to the study.

Participant Category	Number (n)	Age Range	Employment/Occupation
Lesbian	6	18-35	2 unemployed, 2 footballers, 1 banker, 1 teacher
Gay	5	18-35	2 university students, 1 chef, 2 self-employed
Transgender	3	18-35	2 self-employed, 1 human rights activist,
Intersex	4	18-35	1 football player, 2 unemployed
Total	17	18-35	

Source: Researcher's field data (2026)

4.2 COMMUNITY UNDERSTANDING AND AWARENESS OF LGBTQ+ IDENTITIES

This research captured the general community understanding of LGBTQ identities and examined how such perceptions influence the lived experiences of LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe. Generally, there are many misconceptions surrounding LGBTQ persons, largely influenced by religious and cultural values deeply embedded within society. The researcher noted that many community members do not fully understand what it means to be LGBTQ, and as a result, many believe that homosexuality is a Western influence that has contributed to the decline of society's moral values. These perceptions are reinforced by rigid cultural and religious beliefs, which most respondents described as restrictive and harmful.

Respondent A stated:

I grew up in a ghetto, and I could hear people discussing about homosexuality and how it is inconsistent with the cultural values of Zimbabwe where same-sex relationships are a taboo and a thing from the West and Un-African. People always say that marriage is always defined as union between a man and a woman and anything outside that cannot be accepted.

These experiences show that there is limited understanding of what it really means to be LGBTQ, which contributes to the discrimination and stigma which LGBTQ persons experience in their everyday life. There appears to be little public knowledge or education regarding sexual diversity, resulting in continued social exclusion and marginalization. The community frequently assumes that homosexuality is a choice and that individuals willingly decide to engage in same sex relationships. Heterosexual individuals fail to understand that sexual orientation, as people do not choose who they are emotionally or physically attracted to. Some community members also perceive homosexuality as a disease and believe that associating with LGBTQ persons may influence others to become gay, further fueling hatred and discrimination within communities.

Several research participants described that they ended up leaving the communities they grew up in, because of the verbal abuse and harassment they experienced daily due to their sexual orientation. In Zimbabwe, sexuality has always been viewed in binary terms, thus men expected

to love women and women expected to love men. This rigid understanding of sexuality creates an environment in which LGBTQ individuals continue to face persecution and exclusion from society.

Responded B stated:

I was told that marriage is only between a male and a female and anything other than that cannot be considered in the society. I tried to explain what it means to be LGBTQ+, but no one wanted to be educated about this topic hence I just let them be and believe what they think is right.

The way most Zimbabweans are socialized contributes significantly to the judgement and discrimination directed towards LGBTQ individuals. Growing up, every child is taught that heterosexuality is the only acceptable norm, both at home and in institutions such as schools, churches and the media. Social media has also become a breeding ground for misinformation and disinformation about sexual minorities in Zimbabwe. Popular online platforms such as ZimCelebs, DJ Sparks Podcast and Chimanda TV have hosted LGBTQ persons on their platforms often receiving mixed and sometimes hostile reactions from the public. One gay participant mentioned that the online responses were emotionally disturbing and could easily lead someone into depression. Although LGBTQ individuals and advocacy groups have attempted to challenge and clarify misconceptions surrounding sexual minorities, misunderstanding and negative perceptions continue to persist within the community.

These findings can be understood through the Minority Stress Theory (MST), which explains that sexual minorities experience chronic stress because of stigma, prejudice, discrimination and social exclusion within a heteronormative society. In Zimbabwe, prevailing attitudes characterize the identities and practices of sexual minorities as sinful, "un-African," or Western, resulting in persistent hostility and rejection from family members, communities, religious institutions, and other social groups. Participant narratives corroborate the presence of stressors identified in Minority Stress Theory, such as discrimination, victimisation, verbal abuse, and social prejudice. The fear of rejection and negative societal attitudes toward LGBTQ individuals may contribute to the internalisation of stigma, concealment of identity, and social withdrawal as protective strategies. These dynamics are reflected in participants' accounts of leaving their communities after experiencing discrimination and rejection. Furthermore, Minority Stress Theory suggests that

chronic exposure to these stressors among LGBTQ individuals increases the risk of mental health disorders, including depression and anxiety, as well as general emotional distress and social isolation. Consequently, ongoing discrimination and societal misunderstanding exacerbate the psychological and social challenges faced by LGBTQ individuals.

4.3 DISCRIMINATION IN THE WORKPLACE

The findings showed that workplace discrimination remains one of the biggest challenges which LGBTQ+ members continue to face in their daily lives. Negative social attitudes towards homosexuality are the major causes of workplace discrimination as employers and coworker create toxic and unsafe environments for LGBTQ+ persons. One respondent said that they were laid off their workplace because one person discovered their sexuality and reported it to their boss who wanted to have nothing to do with LGBTQ persons.

Respondent F:

It was hard for me to continue working at X because the big boss found out and he was linked to the ruling party. I had no choice but to leave because he told me that he would report me and have me arrested hence I was left jobless and fearing for my life. This has not only happened to me but a lot of my friends as well who are gay, so it is difficult in this country.

This shows that stigma at the workplace is there and most companies do not want to be engaged with persons who identify as LGBTQ+ as they fear that they might be accused of promoting homosexuality when it is illegal in Zimbabwe. There is also discrimination in the sports departments in Zimbabwe especially in the women's football fraternity. Many lesbians who were interviewed expressed how much they fear coming out as they might lose their place in their teams. Losing their place in the team means that their source of income is no longer there and no one will want to be associated with them.

Respondent L:

I'm afraid that if people and my coaches find out that am attracted to females it will be the end of my career and no one else will want to have me their football club. There is one lesbian girl who used to play football, but when her sexuality was known they laid her off from the football team as well as her job because she was also in the army and no football team ever wanted any association with her.

Most women football players mentioned that concealing their sexuality is very important as it makes them keep their jobs and gives them a little bit of peace. They gave reference to one popular women football player who was axed from the women national football team because she had one sex video which was leaked on WhatsApp platform and pictures in a popular newspaper and the news was all over the country. So, nobody wanted to end up like this football player so concealing their sexuality to keep their jobs was of utmost importance. However, they also mentioned that it is hard to live a life where you cannot express yourself and pretend to be someone else.

Respondent A:

We love our jobs because we earn a living by working, but there is nothing as hard as living a lie just to impress other people whilst oneself is not happy. At the end, that is the reason why some end up being suicidal because they have no peace of mind and they see death as a better solution.

In addition, gay men who are into commercial sex work face a lot of discrimination and abuse when they are only trying to make a living. It is a different case for gays because they experience physical abuse when their clients discover that they are gay. After experiencing physical violence, they cannot report the case to anyone because they would face imprisonment for being homosexual. In Zimbabwe only women who are commercial sex workers are protected by the law hence if they are abused or harassed, they can report and they will be quickly assisted which is a different case for gay men.

Respondent G:

I met guy one night doing my business as usual. One man came and we agreed to go to a private lodge so that I will render him my services Everything went amiss when he discovered that I was male as him as I am a feminine gay. He called other men and they started to beat me. I could only cry for help, but no one helped because no one is willing to help a gay person because of the laws surrounding homosexuality. It was strange because mostly we operate privately and men who come to us know that we are gay, so they usually know what they are up for.

This shows that there is a difference between how male sex workers are treated in contrast to their female counterparts, whether gay or straight but for gay men it comes with imprisonment if you are caught hence no gay person will just handover themselves to the police rather, they endure the physical violence on their own. According to Tsang et al. (2019) enacted stigma and a heightened sense of self stigma among gay sex workers, males experience greater marginalization than female

sex workers. This is because of the differences in laws and policies between male and female sex workers in Zimbabwe.

Furthermore, the taboo surrounding homosexuality often leads LGBTQ+ person to conceal their sexuality fearing that if their sexuality is known they will face discrimination hence they are not able to freely express themselves. Homosexuality is seen as a taboo in Zimbabwe something which is not accepted by the society and is a western value. All participants mentioned that homosexuality is regarded as a taboo hence if you are suspected or known no one wants to be involved with you as it brings bad luck. One women football player mentioned how her team was losing matches and their coach attributed it to many acts of homosexuality among teammates.

Respondent F:

The team had been in a bad state and was performing so badly, but these things happen in football sometimes. The coach threatened to dismiss some players and even report it to the Zimbabwe football governing body if he ever finds out the culprits involved in homosexuality acts. Everyone was afraid to lose their place in team because this could mean their source of income is gone. Everyone who was lesbian started pretending as if they are straight just to keep their jobs.

This shows that it is very difficult for the LGBTQ+ persons to express their sexuality in the workplace because they fear losing their jobs. However, a different case emerged where one transgender woman mentioned that her experiences as a transgender woman in Zimbabwe are different as she has met employers who are more inclusive at the workplace.

Transgender woman:

I have had an uplifting experience in the corporate world and the management, and other employees welcomed me and treated me like an equal. In my case it should have been more difficult to accept because of the animosity that happens when one goes through transition.

Workplace discrimination, fear of termination, concealment of sexual orientation, and harassment reported by participants align with the external pressures described in minority stress theory. These pressures include prejudice, victimization, and discrimination. Many participants indicated that

concealing their sexual orientation is necessary to protect both their employment and personal safety. This illustrates the internalization of fear among LGBTQ individuals. Minority stress theory further posits that these stressors negatively affect the mental health of minority group members. As a result, issues such as anxiety, depression, psychological distress, and, as some interviewees noted, suicidal ideation may occur. Therefore, discrimination against LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwean workplaces exemplifies how societal structures can exert persistent psychological and emotional pressure on sexual minorities.

The questions that are worth asking in the Zimbabwean context are whether businesses are willing to promote the culture of respect and equality in the workplace even if the government won't do it. This can be possible if they understand that someone's sexual orientation does not make them any different from any other employees, if they can do their jobs. Article 1 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) states that 'All human beings are born free in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood. This basically means that every person is entitled to their rights, and they should be respected regardless of their sexual orientation.

4.4 RELIGIOUS AND CULTURAL INFLUENCES

Religious and cultural beliefs are a significant factor to the personal experiences of LGBTQ persons in Zimbabwe. Culture and Religion have been used as tools to discriminate against LGBTQ persons since 1995 when President Robert Mugabe disparaged same sex relationships as not only unnatural and un-African but also unchristian Chibango (2024). According to Karl Marx Christians endure victimization, oppression, exploitation and other forms of injustice because heaven is their goal, hence anyone who goes against the Bible will not see heaven Omonijo et.al (2016). LGBTQ persons suffer a lot of discrimination at the hands of Christians mostly because they are constantly told that it is ungodly and that marriage is only between a man and a woman.

4.4.1 Religious Institutions and the Limits for Safe Spaces for LGBTQ+ persons

Homosexuality is seen as un-African by many African states as 32 out of 54 states criminalize homosexuality. A significant number of respondents mentioned that going to religious places felt very uncomfortable for them because most times the church leaders will be condemning same sex relationships or homosexuality. Therefore, it is difficult to publicly express yourself as lesbian or

gay because you will be told that you are possessed with some kind of demons hence you need deliverance.

Respondent M:

I used to go to church until one day the church pastor called me and said that he has been hearing from other church members that am gay. He said that if I wanted to continue being a choir member I should change my ways otherwise I would have to leave the church because it is unacceptable in the church. I only responded by telling him that am not gay because publicly coming out would have me persecuted yet I still wanted to attend church services.

In light of the above, it shows that fellow Christians and churches are intolerant and very unwelcoming to people who are in same sex relationships hence making it difficult for LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe to lead a normal life. Instead of condemning LGBTQ persons who are also seeking the face of the Lord some respondents mentioned that they only want to be seen as normal people or a neighbor who needs compassion. Kaunda (2015) argues that in the African church there should be openness to dialogue on the same sex relationship and appreciation of human dignity and value of the people involved and not just focus on morality or wrongness.

In addition, LGBTQ community members generally had negative experiences in their churches such that they felt they were no longer part and parcel of their respective churches. This is because words such as satanic, evil, demon demonic, sick, mentally disturbed and tarnishing the church's image were used to describe them in church. Most times when they attend church this is when scriptures which attack them are mostly used hence church is Not a safe place for them.

Respondent E:

I really felt uncomfortable when I was summoned by the female church members to a meeting. It felt like they had been discussing about my appearance for quite a while as they told me that the way I dressed was against what the church expects women to dress. They told me as a female church member when coming to church dress properly like a lady and not like a man. I was so hurt, and this was the last time I attended church in my life as I was told I was tarnishing the church's image.

Despite being ridiculed by church members and being humiliated for being gay, one lesbian and one intersex person revealed that they never felt ashamed of their sexuality as they said that this is who they are and will not change for anyone.

I'm not ashamed of my gender identity; I am proud of it. This is who I am and no one is going to force me to change. I will also continue to attend church services because am only going there to seek the glory of God not opinions about my sexuality.

LGBTQ community members face a lot of ridicule in their day to day lives even in places of worship, however several of them showed strong character as they vowed that even if they are discriminated, they are never going to live a life that is not comfortable for them.

In Zimbabwe, prevailing religious and cultural beliefs frequently contribute to prejudice against LGBTQ individuals by characterizing homosexuality as sinful, un-African, and immoral. Participants reported negative experiences within church settings, including rejection, humiliation, condemnation, and pressure to conceal their identities. These experiences exemplify external stressors as outlined in Minority Stress Theory, which links persistent discrimination to emotional distress, social isolation, and fear of openly expressing one's identity. Despite these challenges, some participants demonstrated resilience by refusing to feel ashamed of their sexuality or gender identity and maintaining a commitment to self-acceptance.

4.4.2 The Church as a Potential Safe Space for LGBTQ

However, research indicates that churches in Zimbabwe remain divided regarding same-sex relationships. This division is evident in both the literature on religion and homosexuality and in the feedback from participants. While most churches denounce homosexuality, there are some that exhibit tolerance towards members of the LGBTQ community. Certain respondents noted that their congregations are inclusive of LGBTQ individuals. An intersex individual pointed out that if church members engage in informed discussions about LGBTQ people, the church could become a haven. Gaining knowledge about gay and lesbian individuals could help reduce stigma and discrimination. The LGBTQ community aspires for the church to recognize them as equal children of God who are simply seeking a connection with the Lord, much like everyone else.

4.4.3 Anti LGBTQ+ Chants by Politicians

Political chants have been used by most politicians to gain popularity and supporters, especially during election time when politicians aspire to gain supporters. President Mugabe denigrated the society of GALZ there have been divided opinions over gays and lesbians not only in Zimbabwe but Africa at large Muparamoto,2020). Mugabe said that gays are worse than dogs and pigs and they will ever engage in homosexual madness and that even insects won't do it Muparamoto,2020). This homophobia by Mugabe still haunts LGBTQ persons up to date as they feel that they have been likened to animals and not humans. LGBTQ persons mentions that some people still degrade them using such terms and that it is heartbreaking as they are not being treated like human beings, and they fear for their lives.

When political leaders make anti-homosexuality statements and use offensive slogans, it adds to the stigma and discrimination faced by LGBTQ people. Using derogatory language, such as calling LGBTQ individuals animals, increases fear and social isolation. According to Minority Stress Theory, this kind of aggression is an outside source of stress that harms the mental health of LGBTQ people. It can lead to emotional distress, greater worries about personal safety, and feelings of being dehumanized.

4.5 Criminalization- Fear of Legal Repercussion

The Constitution of Zimbabwe, under Section 78, explicitly forbids marriage between individuals of the same sex. This legal restriction creates significant challenges for members of the LGBTQ+ community, who may be reluctant to openly identify or express their sexual orientation due to fears of criminalization. Although the law specifically prohibits same-sex marriage rather than homosexuality itself, individuals within the LGBTQ community still encounter stigma and discrimination stemming from a broader societal reluctance to accept diverse sexual orientations. Gay participants discussed how they constantly live in fear of being put behind bars as Section 73 of the [Criminal Law Act 2006 (Codification and Reform Act) [Chapter 9:23]] criminalize 'sodomy' (sexual acts between man). This law is used to prosecute consensual same-sex act hence it becomes difficult for gay persons to fully express themselves. Gay men are the usually the ones who are arrested and detained by police officers who are corrupt and later asks for bribes.

Respondent G stated:

The police once raided a bar in Gweru, and it happened that my partner and I were there that night. My partner is feminine or bottom gay; hence, he was arrested as they said he is a man dressed like a woman. He was detained the whole weekend and was later released on Monday morning after facing physical and verbal abuse. This was a traumatizing experience for him and he hasn't fully recovered.

This indicates that members of the LGBTQ community, particularly gay men, are primarily subjected to scrutiny by both legal systems and society at large, as they frequently encounter challenges related to their sexual orientation. It's important to highlight that while the law does not explicitly reference lesbians, women who love women are still vulnerable to arrest and discrimination. In 2014, the Society of Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe (GALZ) endured significant discrimination and faced legal repercussions. Nevertheless, after an extensive legal process, the Harare Magistrates' Court acquitted GALZ charges related to operating an unregistered organization, which is prohibited by law.

4.6 Consequences of Disclosure and Involuntary Outing Among LGBTQ+ Individuals in Zimbabwe

Self-disclosure, commonly known as 'coming out of the closet,' and involuntary outing tend to result in similar consequences for LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe. A dominant theme which came up from the study participants is family disownment, homelessness and social exclusion. Other themes also emerged and these included blackmail and extortion, mental health problems, loss of livelihood and education and transgender visibility.

4.6.1 Family Disownment and Social Exclusion

LGBTQ+ persons who have voluntarily come out of the closet and those who have been outed described how this has affected their daily in both negative and positive manners. Of the people interviewed 6 were outed and 3 voluntarily came out of the closet and all the others were still in the closet. They described instances when they came out of the closet and how this affected their individual lives. One gay man described coming out voluntarily as one of the worst decisions he has ever made in his life for, he lost all his family members and up to this day no one want to be associated with him.

Respondent G:

I decided to come out to my family because I was tired of living a lie and I wanted to settle down as age was also chasing me. One day I called a family meeting and broke the news that I was gay. That was the last time I talked to my family, it's been 7 years now. They told me that they cannot be associated with me because I had embarrassed them in the community and that they did not raise ngochani (degrading term for gays).

Coming out is not easy but the participants described it as something that one will eventually need to do so that you do not keep hiding or pretending to be someone you are not. However, they described it as difficult and risky process hence they mentioned that it should be managed carefully. This has led many individuals to conceal their sexuality to avoid being rejected as well as social exclusion from the community. Several participants described how life changed the moment they were out. Two participants, one gay and one lesbian narrated how they were forced into marriage or else their families would disown them.

My family immediately started arrangements for me to get married to correct my sexuality. I was forced to marry a girl, yet I did not want to do that, but I had to conform since I did not want to disappoint my family and embarrass them as they mentioned. However, the marriage did not last because I was not being intimate with the woman as I felt nothing towards her. This is the point where my family totally disowned me as they said they can never have a son dating another man as it is a disgrace to the family.

LGBTQ persons are forced to give in to family pressure as they still want support, love and care for their families. Most of the respondents mentioned that there is a sense of compulsory kinship whereby they feel that family is untouchable, and the relationship should be maintained at all costs. This is evidenced by one lesbian who said that she is out to the world and does not worry about everyone other than her mother and father knowing about her sexuality. She fears that if they find out about her sexuality they might break down and never be the same again because they have faith in her that she is a good person and will one day bring home a husband.

Respondent S:

Personally, I am not worried about everyone knowing that I date fellow women, in fact the outside world knows and it's only my mom and dad who do not know. Some days I feel like I want them to know but am afraid to break their hearts as I know that they will never accept me, they go to church and they see this as ungodly. In Zimbabwe we respect families so much that to come out as gay they might disown you.

At the end, some stay in the closet thus concealing their sexuality to avoid parental rejection. The problem with this kind of arrangement is the LGBTQ persons who choose not to disclose their sexuality to their parents live a miserable life and some end up depressed because they cannot fully express themselves since they are not free. They end up losing themselves, their sense of belonging, purpose and identity. LGBTQ who were interviewed also mentioned that there is a lot of LGBTQ persons who are in heterosexual marriages but on the side, they are with their LGBTQ persons. This is because they get married to please their family and society as this is what is expected of them and termed socially correct.

4.6.2 Blackmail and Extortion

Participants reported issues of blackmail and extortion when they are threatened with being outed unless they pay some money or provide favors. This is because you cannot go and report such issues as fear of criminalization hence, they end up falling victim. Several individuals mentioned how they paid some work colleagues a huge sum of money so that they would not out them at the workplace. GALZ has reported several cases where gays and lesbians have been blackmailed and threatened by police or by people who claim to be. One case is of a gay guy who had his apartment stormed by three individual and of them claimed to be a police officer.

Respondent K:

The three people told me that am being charged with have anal sex with other man as well as commenting bad stuff about the President. They asked me to give them US\$300 for them to leave my house and then they left.

Another gay respondent also mentioned that he was picked up by two police officers on allegation that he was also having anal sex with man. On the way to the police station, they demanded money and they released him without any charge when he gave them money. This shows that police

officers and common individuals extort money from LGBTQ persons and instill fear in them as already they already fear criminalization or to be outed hence they give in to extortion. They have nowhere to report cases of extortion because it will be like going to the police to report yourself that you re gay.

It was noted that extortion is not only done or limited to the police, but also by family, neighbors as well as some community members. Mostly gay persons described being aggressively propositioned by individuals who later start asking money from them threatening to reveal their sexuality. Some end up relocating to other cities because the extortionists would be following them demanding more cash, clothes and other forms of payment. This leads to internal displacement of LGBTQ community members as they live their hometown because of such kind of abuse.

Extortion by family members is one of the worst cases because LGBTQ persons believe that at the end their families should be there for them but rather it's not the case. In this case a lesbian was forced to leave home by her stepmother who was threatening to report her sexuality to the police. She was surprised because a few months back the stepmother had told her not to disclose her sexuality to the community members who were suspecting that she was lesbian. As a result, she became homeless and was forced to leave the country and seek employment but later came back as she was living illegally in another country without proper documentation.

However, in a turn of events in Kenya, two men were arrested and given 15 years jail term after they blackmailed two gay men. According to the (Guardian,2026), Abel Meli and Another were sentenced to 15 years in prison for robbery with violence on 3 March 2026 at Milimani law courts Nairobi. This ruling is a rare example of justice being served for the queer community in Kenya. Even though Kenya is part of the 32 countries which criminalize homosexuality in Africa this case shows that there is hope for the queer community as their case was heard in the court of law and justice was served.

GALZ has observed that the high risk of online targeting of LGBTQ community members leads to real-world threats. According to (Staff Report, 2025), GALZ reported that in 2022, a gay man was lured via social media under the pretence of friendship but became a victim of extortion and disclosure threats in Bulawayo. This illustrates the ongoing suffering of LGBTQ community members at the hands of a society that should uphold their human rights, as these rights belong to

everyone, regardless of sexual orientation. There is no legal protection for this community, so members continue to live in fear and remain constantly vigilant.

4.6.3 Violence and Abuse

Many LGBTQ community members live in fear of violence and abuse, this is because they have experienced it or witnessed some members of the LGBTQ community being abused. LGBTQ members experience physical, verbal and even sexual violence which is termed as corrective rape. Most lesbians fear sexual violence as is common in lesbians than in gays. A significant number of lesbians women attracted to women reported situations where heterosexual men threatened them with sexual assault to deter them from their sexual orientation. As a result, many live in a constant state of fear and choose to move into private neighborhoods that offer a sense of safety. Nonetheless, some have pointed out that not everyone has the financial means to reside in such secure areas, leaving them in denser suburban environments.

All LGBTQ individuals reported experiencing verbal abuse in their lives. Verbal abuse was the most frequently mentioned, with degrading words like 'ngochani' and 'stabane' (GAY) commonly used to refer to members of the LGBTQ community. They all agreed that these words are extremely derogatory and make them feel excluded from the larger Zimbabwean community. Due to their masculine attire, masculine lesbians are often called derogatory names, and sometimes they fear walking freely as they are mostly verbally abused.

Abuse against the LGBTQ community, including physical, verbal, and sexual violence, is an example of environmental stressors described in Minority Stress Theory. LGBTQ people often face threats like corrective rape, verbal harassment, and physical assault, which force them to be cautious and hide parts of who they are. Slurs such as "ngochani" and "stabane" (degrading names for gays and lesbians) make feelings of exclusion, fear, and emotional distress even worse for LGBTQ individuals. According to Minority Stress Theory, ongoing exposure to these hostile and harmful environments can damage psychological well-being.

4.7 Transgender Visibility

The experiences of transgender individuals appeared to be particularly difficult and challenging because unlike sexual orientation which can be hidden it is difficult to hide gender identity which is more visible. Transgender are people assigned male or female at birth, and they transition to match how they want to be identified as. Transgender persons who were interviewed mentioned frequent instances of when they were discriminated and misunderstood. The most common issue is that of identification where their documents do not match with their current selves after transitioning. In Zimbabwe, even after transitioning you cannot change your documents to go along with your current gender identity. One transgender man recalls an instance where he wanted to travel to South Africa for an LGBTQ+ and how he was denied crossing the border as his documents did not match his gender identity.

Respondent T:

I was denied crossing the border at the Zimbabwean side to go to South Africa because my passport was showing that I was a woman, yet I had gone through transition as I was a man now. They said that I should go back and bring my original passport not someone else otherwise they would get me arrested. I was forced to cancel my journey because at this point I could not convince them otherwise.

This is a very difficult situation for transgender persons in Zimbabwe as it is not possible to change their documentation to match their gender identity. In this case, the transgender man was forced to remain calm and cancel his journey as this was causing problems for him to the point where they wanted to call the police for him. This is however in contrast with how South Africa treats transgender people who have transitioned. They are given new documentation to match their new gender identity although they face other LGBTQ related problems their government allows them to acquire proper documentation (Igual 2021).

In South Africa it is a different case as the Alteration of Sex Description and Sex Status Act 49 of 2003 (Act 49) is the law that provides for legal gender recognition. This allows South Africans to change their gender markers on their identity documents after they have transitioned or when they are taking hormone replacement therapy as well as intersex person. According to (Iranti, 2016) accessing employment, healthcare, education records, banking services, driver's license, travel,

voting and social assistance often require proper documentation. In as much as it might take time to get the documentation which matches their gender identity it becomes easy for them to break into society and be treated the same way as any other human being. In Zimbabwe it is a different case because there is no law that protects transgender and intersex person. One transwoman recalls a moment when she was discriminated against when she went to look for employment:

I went to a popular restaurant for an interview, and I had the qualifications to become a Chef. During the interview they asked me if I was male or female, before I could answer they looked at my ID which said male and looked at me again with disgust. The interviewer just straight up told me that I would confuse the customers with my looks hence they denied me the job. I was heartbroken but I vowed to start my own business as I realized that no company was going to employ me as my ID did not match my identity.

This is basically the plight of transgender persons in Zimbabwe as they continue to face discrimination and exclusion in many areas of their daily life. The outside world is so much harsh to transgender persons even though they have families which are welcoming and have accepted their gender identity.

To add on, transgender persons described how medical personnel lack understanding and sensitivity especially the hormone replacement therapy (HRT) for transgender persons. Most transgender persons mentioned that they self-medicate but this is quite dangerous as they might overdose and have health complications. GALZ has been coming through for transgender persons as they have a wellness center, and they have collaborated with some medical personnel who come at the GALZ offices and give them hormonal treatment. This has helped the transgender community to some extent although there is need to educate more medical personnel about the existence of transgender people in Zimbabwe since being LGBTQ+ is illegal in Zimbabwe.

Transgender individuals in this study encounter both social and structural challenges, including workplace discrimination, difficulties in obtaining legal documentation, denial of entry at borders, and barriers to accessing appropriate healthcare. When perceived as differing from their official documents, transgender people often experience humiliation, rejection, and persistent questioning regarding their identity in public spaces. Minority Stress Theory posits that repeated exposure to prejudice and institutionalized discrimination negatively affects psychological well-being,

resulting in emotional disturbances, anxiety, and feelings of exclusion. Barriers to accessing hormone replacement therapy (HRT) and hospital treatment further exemplify the marginalization of transgender individuals by both societal and institutional structures in Zimbabwe. However, certain participants exhibited resilience by securing alternative sources of income and healthcare, including support from organizations such as GALZ.

4.8 COPING MECHANISMS

4.8.1 Concealing Sexuality

Many LGBTQ community members reported that concealing their sexuality is perceived as the most effective means of self-protection and achieving a better quality of life. Participants indicated that disclosure of their sexual orientation could result in severe negative consequences, including depression, substance abuse, or suicidal thoughts. Concealment was identified as the most prevalent coping strategy, despite its significant psychological toll, as living inauthentically can be mentally exhausting. Respondents also recounted instances where families only learned of their children's sexual orientation posthumously, as evidenced by the presence of numerous LGBTQ individuals at the funeral.

4.8.2 Selective Disclosure

Selective disclosure is an additional strategy employed by LGBTQ individuals to navigate life in countries where homosexuality is illegal. This approach involves confiding their sexual orientation to trusted close friends. Such selective disclosure fosters a sense of belonging by providing individuals with confidants to whom they can turn for relationship advice. Members of the LGBTQ community reported confiding in close friends about their sexuality to seek support and companionship, especially during challenging periods. One gay participant described the difficulty of disclosing their sexual orientation to friends, emphasizing that the experience was ultimately positive because they were accepted rather than judged. This participant further indicated that their overall quality of life has improved, as they previously lacked someone with whom to share their struggles but now benefit from a supportive and understanding network.

Selective disclosure serves as a protective strategy that enables LGBTQ community members to avoid victimization while fostering social connections. Disclosing sexual orientation exclusively to trusted friends allows individuals to obtain support and companionship essential for managing the emotional stress linked to concealment. According to Minority Stress Theory, social support

can alleviate the negative impact of minority stress on the well-being of LGBTQ individuals residing in challenging environments, such as Zimbabwe.

4.8.3 Utilization of Safe Spaces

LGBTQ centres in Zimbabwe serve as essential support systems for LGBTQ individuals. Organizations such as Gays and Lesbians of Zimbabwe (GALZ), PAKASIPITI (a feminist organization), and TRANSSMART for transgender and intersex persons provide safe environments where community members can express themselves freely and without fear. These centres have proven particularly beneficial to LGBTQ community members, who report feeling secure within these spaces. This sense of safety is largely attributed to the government's legal recognition of these organizations, which allows them to advocate for the rights of LGBTQ persons in Zimbabwe. However, one community member recounted an incident when GALZ was raided by police, causing significant fear among the LGBTQ community after the Director of GALZ was detained and subsequently released.

For a few months, LGBTQ persons were scared to meet up in these safe places, but with the intervention of lawyers, now GALZ cannot be raided, as it is a nongovernmental organization operating legally with rights. All the above centres have been helpful to the overall LGBTQ community because they continuously support them as well as educating them about their rights which they should enjoy despite the law criminalizing same sex marriages.

Minority Stress Theory is employed in this research to demonstrate that LGBTQ individuals actively seek coping mechanisms and environments that foster resilience against stigma, discrimination, and exclusion. Organizations such as GALZ, PAKASIPITI, and TRANSSMART serve as safe spaces where social support mitigates minority stress. These groups provide open communication, psychological support, legal rights education, and a sense of belonging free from discrimination. Minority Stress Theory further posits that positive social networks and supportive environments offer protection against mental health challenges resulting from prejudice. Despite the fear and insecurity generated by police raids, these organizations continue to play a crucial role in promoting resilience and safety for LGBTQ individuals in Zimbabwe.

4.8.4 Establishing Safe Spaces and Substance Dependency

LGBTQ community members have created safe spaces that allow them to discuss and share their experiences in private, without the need to reveal their sexuality to others or their families. Many individuals have resorted to substance use, which often proves detrimental as they begin to misuse these substances to cope with stress. A transgender man reviewed how he lost one of his friends to drug abuse after her liver was destroyed by mutoriro (crystal meth). It was when she was dismissed from her football team because of her sexuality, and she engaged in substance abuse to minimize stress, as she had lost her source of living.

The majority of those interviewed reported establishing private social media accounts to foster connections. One lesbian participant mentioned being part of a WhatsApp group comprised of masculine lesbians, where they exchange various topics and job opportunities relevant to their community. Within these groups, they find comfort and acceptance due to shared sexual identities, which eliminate judgment based on their sexuality.

5 CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 CONCLUSION

The research comprehensively explored the personal experiences of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe. This is a community that is marginalized because of the anti LGBTQ laws that exist in Zimbabwe. LGBTQ community members face a lot of discrimination and stigma because of their sexual orientation. The laws prohibiting same sex marriages makes it difficult for LGBTQ persons to freely express their sexuality in public as they fear stigma and discrimination. Section 78(3) of the Constitution of Zimbabwe which bans same sex marriage is the who which perpetrates discrimination based on sexuality for LGBTQ members in Zimbabwe. Inasmuch Zimbabwe is signatory to international human rights treaties it still discriminates against LGBTQ members meaning they are not abiding by the rules of international treaties.

Furthermore, religion and culture are also major drivers of continued stigma and discrimination of LGBTQ in Zimbabwe. Religious people constantly and continuously attack this group of people and cites that Sodom and Gomorrah was destroyed because of gays hence to be involved in homosexuality is ungodly. Homosexuality is unacceptable in Zimbabwe, and they have managed to spread the notion that everyone involved is possessed with demons, and they need to be cleansed such that they do not spread it among the society. Former President of Zimbabwe, Robert Mugabe even described gays as worse than dogs and pigs and that this can never be unacceptable in Zimbabwe.

In addition, the highlights that LGBTQ persons experience stigma and discrimination because of culture. Zimbabwe disregards homosexuality on the basis that marriage should be between a man and a woman and that is the norm. Growing up children are taught that marriage is between a man and a woman even at school and churches this is what they are taught. This has made gays and lesbians to not publicly express their sexuality as they fear judgement and rebuke from family. At the end they conceal their sexuality, but it has consequences, for example they end up sinking into depression and some end up abusing stress to cope with the pressure of being homosexual and hiding your sexuality.

5.2 RECOMMENDATIONS

- Sensitization of the society regarding the existence of the LGBTQ persons in Zimbabwe and that they deserve to be treated equally as human beings. They should be put processes in place where people are educated on what it means to be LGBTQ. This is largely because the Zimbabwean society does not believe that one can be gay or lesbian hence, they say it is ungodly and un-African. Sensitization should be done in schools, churches, social media platforms so that people make informed conversations about the LGBTQ community. Step by step this might foster acceptance and less discrimination among communities.
- The researcher believes that much sensitization is needed on the existence of intersex persons and that they are normal people who were only born with ambiguous features. Intersex people are a community that is being neglected but even faces more challenges hence the government should do more work on this group of people for them to be accepted by society as they are.
- Mental health facilities meant for queer people should be established since LGBTQ are at higher risk of mental health issues, yet they do not have many places they go to because it is hard to reveal your sexuality even when one needs psycho-social support. GALZ have established a mental health corner for their community members but because the community is growing there is need to establish more mental health facilities in more provinces, especially in rural areas. LGBTQ community members remain marginalized as most of the things are centered in the capital city Harare, and they are usually left behind.
- The government should allow transgender and intersex persons to change gender markers on identity documents. This change would help them fully enjoy their rights as citizens of Zimbabwe. Currently, their documents often do not match their physical appearance. Changing gender markers would make access to banking, healthcare, and voting easier, significantly improving their lives.

- Sustainable Development Goal 3 aims to ensure healthy lives and promote well-being for people of all ages by 2030. The government of Zimbabwe should require public medical facilities to provide gender-affirming services and hormone replacement therapy for transgender people. In addition, there should be strong systems in place to protect intersex minors from harm and surgeries they have not agreed to. These protections are important because surgeries done without consent in childhood can make it harder for intersex people to decide their own gender identity later in life.
- The larger community should stop hate speech towards the LGBTQ community as well as use of derogatory terms to describe this community as these are some of the reasons which lead them to abuse drugs and resort to alcohol so that they do not stress about people denigrating them as if they are not human beings.

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List of Abbreviations

ACHPR	African Charter on Human and People's Right
CoZ	Constitution of Zimbabwe
HIV/AIDS	Human Immunodeficiency Virus/Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome
ILGA	International Lesbian Gay Bisexual Trans and Intersex Association
LBT	Lesbian Bisexual Transgender
LEGABIBO	Lesbian, Gays and Bisexuals of Botswana
LGBT	Lesbian Gay Bisexual Transgender
LGBTQ	Lesbian Gay Bisexual Transgender Queer
MST	Minority Stress Theory
NGO	Non-governmental Organizations
PrEP	Pre-Exposure Prophylaxis
UNAIDS	Jointed United Nations Programme on HIV/AIDS

Appendix 1: Informed Consent Guide

My name is COLLETA JESINAU (Student No 99193), a final year master's in international Territorial Studies student from Mendel University in Brno. I am carrying out a study on **PERSONAL EXPERIENCES OF LGBTQ+ COMMUNITY MEMBERS IN ZIMBABWE**. I am kindly asking you to participate in this study by answering interview questions so that I can be able to understand the day-to-day experiences of LGBTQ+ persons in a country where it is a crime.

Overview of the Study:

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of the study is for the researcher to gather information on the personal day to day experiences of LGBTQ community members in Zimbabwe. The researcher wants to understand how the community manage to navigate life in a country where same sex relationships are prohibited. You have been selected to participate in this study because is because you fall in the LGBTQ category thus you will help the researcher to gain an insight into your daily experiences as a LGBTQ member.

Procedure and Duration

If you decide to take part, you will have to be available for a one-on-one WhatsApp phone call interview or Microsoft team's meeting. You will choose between these two and then we can schedule an interview according to your availability. The interviews will range between 15-30 minutes, and we will talk about your personal experiences as an LGBTQ person.

Risks and Discomforts

Due to the nature of the study, research participants might find some questions difficult to answer as they might feel that they do not want to share confidential information. The participants are allowed not to answer questions which they feel might trigger their feelings of discomfort.

Compensation

There are no monetary benefits or compensation for participating in this study for the research is for solely for academic purposes. However, the research might benefit the LGBTQ community members as they have been given a platform to talk about their experiences. The research might

be read by different kinds of people, and they will have an appreciation of the LGBTQ community and how they need to be treated as human beings despite their identities.

Confidentiality

No real names of study participants will be used in the research; the study participants will not be asked their real names during the interviews. The researcher will make use of the participant gender identities, alphabet letter or pseudo names to identify participants. The information which the participants disclose will not be shared with anyone but only used for the research purposes hence the participants' right to privacy will be respected and information will remain confidential

Voluntary Participation

The study participants will voluntarily participate in this research. If at any time they are not comfortable they are free to withdraw their consent without any penalties or harm.

Offer to answer questions

You are free to ask any questions regarding this study before you sign this form, and the researcher will explain everything in detail and in language you most understand.

Authorisation

If you will participate in the study, please put your signature in the space below to show that you have read and understood how the research will be conducted and have agreed to participate. For confidentiality purposes you can put pseudo name or your gender identity.

Name and Surname

Date

Signature

Appendix 2: Semi-Structured Interview Guide

Title of Study

Personal Experiences of LGBTQ Community Members in Zimbabwe

Interview Structure

Section A: Participant Background Information

1. Age range, gender identity
2. Sexual orientation (optional)
3. Occupation

Section B: Lived Experiences and Identity

4. Could you tell us about your daily life as an LGBTQ person in Zimbabwe?
5. When and with whom do you normally share or not share your identity?

Section C: Family, Culture and Religion

6. Can you tell us about your experiences with family, culture, or religion related to your identity?

Section D: Laws and Access to Services

7. How, if at all, have laws and government policies affected your life?
8. What have your experiences been when accessing services such as healthcare or interacting with authorities?

Section E: Wellbeing and Support

9. How have these experiences affected your mental health or wellbeing?
10. What support systems or communities have been important to you?

Section F: Digital Spaces and Social Change

11. Do you use online or digital spaces to connect with others or stay safe? If so, how?
12. Looking back, do you feel things have changed for LGBTQ+ people in Zimbabwe? What changes have you noticed?

Closing Question

13. Is there anything else you would like to share about your experiences?